



United States Department of the Interior

INTERIOR BUSINESS CENTER
Washington, DC 20240

SECTION 1 – INTRODUCTION

1. Combined Synopsis/Solicitation

- 1.1.** This is a combined synopsis/solicitation for commercial products or commercial services prepared in accordance with Federal Acquisition Regulations (FAR) part 12. This announcement constitutes the only solicitation. Offers are being requested and a separate written solicitation will not be issued.

Solicitation number **140D0426Q0324** is issued as a request for quotation (RFQ) for Artificial Intelligence (AI) Chatbot Services to enhance agency Recruitment Efforts.

This acquisition is a total small business set-aside. This solicitation incorporates provisions and clauses by reference. The full text of provisions and clauses may be accessed electronically at www.acquisition.gov.

- 1.2.** The period of performance for this Purchase Order will consist of a one-year Base Period estimated to begin on June 1, 2026, followed by four (4) one-year Option Periods, as outlined in the table below. If all options are exercised, the total period of performance will not exceed five (5) years. Continued performance under this Purchase Order is contingent upon the availability of funds and the Contractor's acceptable level of performance.

- Base Period: June 01, 2026, to May 31, 2027
- Option Period 1: June 01, 2027, to May 31, 2028
- Option Period 2: June 01, 2028, to May 31, 2029
- Option Period 3: June 01, 2029, to May 31, 2030
- Option Period 4: June 01, 2030, to May 31, 2031

- 1.3.** The U.S. Department of the Interior (DOI), Interior Business Center (IBC), Acquisition Services Directorate (AQD), is issuing this RFQ on behalf of the Peace Corps (PC), Office of Volunteer Recruitment and Service (VRS), for Artificial Intelligence (AI) Chatbot Services to enhance agency Recruitment Efforts.

The Peace Corps seeks a FedRAMP High authorized, commercially available SaaS conversational AI solution ("Chatbot") to enhance recruitment, outreach, and public engagement across peacecorps.gov. The solution must deliver high-quality, secure, and scalable interactions with the public while integrating seamlessly with existing systems.

Through the implementation of the integrated conversational AI chatbot service, the Peace Corps expects to:

- Facilitate more effective and efficient interactions between potential applicants with recruiters and the marketing team.
- Generate new leads through an additional marketing channel.
- Increase the number of leads converted into applicants through better just-in-time communications.
- Decrease the time and effort Peace Corps staff spend responding to commonly asked questions and requests for guidance from the public that can be answered through thoughtfully constructed technology.
- Provide smoother and more seamless interactions between the public and Peace Corps through escalation of AI generated conversations, when required, to the relevant Peace Corps staff.

1.4. Place of Performance

All services provided by the Contractor are to be conducted at the Contractor's location within the United States of America; no on-site work at the Government facility is anticipated.

1.5. Administrative Considerations

All questions and concerns during performance of this effort shall be directed to the Contracting Officer (CO), Contract Specialist (CS), and Contracting Officers Representative (COR) identified below:

- The CO for this effort is as follows:
Michael McGuire
Department of the Interior
Interior Business Center
Acquisition Services Directorate
Email: mike_mcguire@ibc.doi.gov
- The CS for this effort is as follows:
Jacqueline Hernandez
Department of the Interior
Interior Business Center
Acquisition Services Directorate
Email: jacqueline_hernandez@ibc.doi.gov
- ***Note: The COR for this will be provided at time of award.***

1.6. The provision at 52.212-1, Instructions to Offerors—Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Sep 2023), applies to this acquisition and the RFQ includes an addendum to the provision. See Section 4 of the RFQ for more information. Additional provisions can be found in section 3 of the RFQ.

1.7. The clause at 52.212-4, Terms and Conditions—Commercial Products and Commercial Services, applies to this acquisition. See Section 3 of the RFQ for additional clauses.

1.8. Submission of Questions

Questions related to this RFQ package must be received electronically via email to CO Michael McGuire; Email: mike_mcguire@ibc.doi.gov, and CS Jacqueline Hernandez; Email: jacqueline_hernandez@ibc.doi.gov, no later than **April 10, 2026 at 12:00PM EST**.

All questions must be received in writing – No oral questions will be accepted. All e-mail inquiries must have **“Questions – RFQ # 140D0426Q0324”** in the subject line. The Government’s responses will be provided via email.

1.9. Submission of Quote

Quotes must be received via email to Michael McGuire (mike_mcguire@ibc.doi.gov) and Jacqueline Hernandez (jacqueline_hernandez@ibc.doi.gov) no later than **10:00 A.M. ET, May 04, 2026**. Reference **“Quote – 140D0426Q0324”** in the subject line.

The Government reserves the right to contact a Quoter regarding their quote including to request additional discounts.

Late submissions may not be considered for evaluation at the discretion of the Contracting Officer. No faxed or hard copy quotes will be accepted.

1.10. Anticipated Award Type

The Government anticipates awarding a Firm-Fixed-Price (FFP) Purchase Order as a result of this RFQ. Travel / Other Direct Costs (ODCs) are not anticipated in performance of this order.

1.11. Codes for services or supplies:

- **North American Industry Classification System (NAICS):** 541519 – Other Computer Related Services (SB size standard \$34M).
- **Product Service Code (PSC):** DA10 – IT and Telecom – Business Application / Application Development Software as a Service.

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[END OF SECTION 1]

SECTION 2 – PERFORMANCE WORK STATEMENT (PWS)

PLEASE SEE ATTACHMENT 1: PWS

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[END OF SECTION 2]

SECTION 3 - GENERAL PURCHASE ORDER TERMS AND CONDITIONS**3.1 CLAUSES****FAR 52.252-2 Clauses Incorporated by Reference (Feb 1998)**

This contract incorporates one or more clauses by reference, with the same force and effect as if they were given in full text. Upon request, the Contracting Officer will make their full text available. Also, the full text of a clause may be accessed electronically at this address:

<http://acquisition.gov/far/index.html>;

The following clauses are hereby incorporated by reference:

Name	Title	Date
52.203-3	Gratuities	Apr 1984
52.203-6	Restrictions on Subcontractor Sales to the Government-- Alternate I	Jun 2020
52.203-17	Contractor Employee Whistleblower Rights	Nov 2023
52.203-19	Prohibition on Requiring Certain Internal Confidentiality Agreements or Statements	Jan 2017
52.204-9	Personal Identity Verification of Contractor Personnel	Jan 2011
52.204-13	System for Award Management—Maintenance	Oct 2018
52.204-14	Service Contract Reporting Requirements	Oct 2016
52.204-19	Incorporation by Reference of Representations and Certifications	Dec 2014
52.209-6	Protecting the Government's Interest When Subcontracting with Contractors Debarred, Suspended, or Proposed for Debarment	Jan 2025
52.209-9	Updates of Publicly Available Information Regarding Responsibility Matters	Oct 2018
52.209-10	Prohibition on Contracting with Inverted Domestic Corporations	Nov 2015
52.212-4	Contract Terms and Conditions—Commercial Products and Commercial Services	Nov 2023
52.219-6	Notice of Total Small Business Set-Aside	Mar 2020
52.219-8	Utilization of Small Business Concerns	Jan 2025
52.219-14	Limitations on Subcontracting	Oct 2022
52.219-28	Post-Award Small Business Program Rerepresentation	Jan 2025
52.222-3	Convict Labor	Jan 2003
52.222-35	Equal Opportunity for Veterans	Jun 2014
52.222-36	Equal Opportunity for Workers with Disabilities	Jun 2020
52.222-37	Employment Reports on Veterans	Jun 2020
52.222-40	Notification of Employee Rights Under the National Labor Relations Act	Dec 2010
52.222-50	Combating Trafficking in Persons	Oct 2025
52.222-54	Employment Eligibility Verification	Jan 2025
52.223-23	Sustainable Products and Services	May 2024
52.224-3	Privacy Training with Alternate 1	Jan 2017
52.226-7	Drug-Free Workplace	May 2024

52.226-8	Encouraging Contractor Policies to Ban Text Messaging While Driving	May 2024
52.229-12	Tax on Certain Foreign Procurements	Feb 2021
52.232-33	Payment by Electronic Funds Transfer—System for Award Management	Oct 2018
52.232-39	Unenforceability of Unauthorized Obligations	Jun 2013
52.232-40	Providing Accelerated Payments to Small Business Subcontractors	Mar 2023
52.233-3	Protest After Award	Aug 1996
52.233-4	Applicable Law for Breach of Contract Claim	Oct 2004
52.240-90	Security Prohibitions and Exclusions Representations and Certifications	Dec 2025
52.240-91	Security Prohibitions and Exclusions	Dec 2025
52.242-13	Bankruptcy	Jul 1995

(End of clause)

FAR 52.217-9 Option to Extend the Term of the Contract (Mar 2000)

- (a) The Government may extend the term of this contract by written notice to the Contractor within one (1) day, provided that the Government gives the Contractor a preliminary written notice of its intent to extend at least three 3 days before the contract expires. The preliminary notice does not commit the Government to an extension.
- (b) If the Government exercises this option, the extended contract shall be considered to include this option clause.
- (c) The total duration of this contract, including the exercise of any options under this clause, shall not exceed five (5) years.

(End of clause)

FAR 52.219-14 Limitations on Subcontracting (DEVIATION OCT 2022)

- (a) This clause does not apply to the unrestricted portion of a partial set-aside.
- (b) *Definition. Similarly situated entity*, as used in this clause, means a first-tier subcontractor, including an independent contractor, that—
- (1) Has the same small business program status as that which qualified the prime contractor for the award (e.g., for a small business set-aside contract, any small business concern, without regard to its socioeconomic status); and
 - (2) Is considered small for the size standard under the North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) code the prime contractor assigned to the subcontract.
- (c) *Applicability*. This clause applies only to—
- (1) Contracts that have been set aside for any of the small business concerns identified in 19.000(a)(3);
 - (2) Part or parts of a multiple-award contract that have been set aside for any of the small business concerns identified in 19.000(a)(3);
 - (3) Contracts that have been awarded on a sole-source basis in accordance with sections 19.105, 19.106, 19.107, and 19.108;

(4) Orders expected to exceed the simplified acquisition threshold and that are set aside for small business concerns under multiple-award contracts, as described in 8.4 and 16.5;

(5) Orders, regardless of dollar value, that are set aside in accordance with sections 19.105, 19.106, 19.107, and 19.108 under multiple-award contracts, as described in 8.4 and 16.5; and

(6) Contracts using the HUBZone price evaluation preference to award to a HUBZone small business concern unless the concern waived the evaluation preference.

(d) *Independent contractors*. An independent contractor shall be considered a subcontractor.

(e) By submission of an offer and execution of a contract, the Contractor agrees that in performance of a contract assigned a North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) code for—

(1) Services (except construction), it will not pay more than 50 percent of the amount paid by the Government for contract performance to subcontractors that are not similarly situated entities. Any work that a similarly situated entity further subcontracts will count towards the prime contractor's 50 percent subcontract amount that cannot be exceeded. When a contract includes both services and supplies, the 50 percent limitation shall apply only to the service portion of the contract;

(2) Supplies (other than procurement from a nonmanufacturer of such supplies), it will not pay more than 50 percent of the amount paid by the Government for contract performance, excluding the cost of materials, to subcontractors that are not similarly situated entities. Any work that a similarly situated entity further subcontracts will count towards the prime contractor's 50 percent subcontract amount that cannot be exceeded. When a contract includes both supplies and services, the 50 percent limitation shall apply only to the supply portion of the contract;

(3) General construction, it will not pay more than 85 percent of the amount paid by the Government for contract performance, excluding the cost of materials, to subcontractors that are not similarly situated entities. Any work that a similarly situated entity further subcontracts will count towards the prime contractor's 85 percent subcontract amount that cannot be exceeded; or

(4) Construction by special trade contractors, it will not pay more than 75 percent of the amount paid by the Government for contract performance, excluding the cost of materials, to subcontractors that are not similarly situated entities. Any work that a similarly situated entity further subcontracts will count towards the prime contractor's 75 percent subcontract amount that cannot be exceeded.

(f) The Contractor shall comply with the limitations on subcontracting as follows:

(1) For contracts, in accordance with paragraphs (c)(1), (2), (3) and (6) of this clause—

[*Contracting Officer check as appropriate.*]

☐ By the end of the base term of the contract and then by the end of each subsequent option period; or

☐ By the end of the performance period for each order issued under the contract.

(2) For orders, in accordance with paragraphs (c)(4) and (5) of this clause, by the end of the performance period for the order.

(g) A joint venture agrees that, in the performance of the contract, the applicable percentage specified in paragraph (e) of this clause will be performed by the aggregate of the joint venture participants.

(1) In a joint venture comprised of a small business protégé and its mentor approved by the Small Business Administration, the small business protégé shall perform at least 40 percent of the work performed by the joint venture. Work performed by the small business protégé in the joint venture must be more than administrative functions.

(2) In an 8(a) joint venture, the 8(a) participant(s) shall perform at least 40 percent of the work performed by the joint venture. Work performed by the 8(a) participants in the joint venture must be more than administrative functions.

(End of clause)

Limitation on Subcontracting Report

In order to ensure compliance with 52.219-14 Limitations on Subcontracting (DEVIATION OCT 2022), the contractor shall also submit a report (Attachment 2) to the Contracting Officer 60 days prior to the end of the base period and all option periods during the purchase order performance. If the Contractor's costs* are below the minimum performance measures stipulated at FAR 52.219-14 (Deviation), the Contractor shall provide a detailed mitigation plan on how it is going to cure its failure to comply with 52.219-14 (Deviation). This mitigation plan shall be provided to both the Small Business Administration and the Contracting Officer. The Contracting Officer will evaluate the plan to assess the adequacy. This clause does not limit the rights and remedies of the government under other contract clauses, including but not limited to the default or termination provisions of the contract.

**As stipulated in FAR 52.219-14 (DEVIATION OCT 2022)*

FAR 52.252-6 Authorized Deviations in Clauses (Apr 1984)

(a) The use in this solicitation or contract of any Federal Acquisition Regulation (48 CFR Chapter 1) clause with an authorized deviation is indicated by the addition of "(DEVIATION)" after the date of the clause.

(b) The use in this solicitation or contract of any Department of the Interior (48 CFR Chapter 14) and Health and Human Services (48 CFR Chapter 3) clause with an authorized deviation is indicated by the addition of "(DEVIATION)" after the name of the regulation.

(End of clause)

DOI-AAAP-0028 Electronic Invoicing and Payment Requirements – Invoice Processing Platform (IPP) (February 2021)

Payment requests must be submitted electronically through the U. S. Department of the Treasury's Invoice Processing Platform System (IPP).

"Payment request" means any request for contract financing payment or invoice payment by the Contractor. To constitute a proper invoice, the payment request must comply with the requirements identified in the applicable Prompt Payment clause included in the contract, or the clause 52.212-4 Contract Terms and Conditions – Commercial Items included in commercial item contracts. The IPP website address is: <https://www.ipp.gov>.

Under this contract, the following documents are required to be submitted as an attachment to the IPP invoice:

- **Invoice Contents:** Invoices will be paid upon approval and acceptance by the Government COR. Invoices must include, as a minimum, the following information:
 - Contractor name

- Contractor address
- Service Order No.
- Invoice date and number
- Billing Period for the services performed
- FFP Deliverable (if FFP)
- ODC Total with corresponding breakout (if applicable)
- Additional supporting documentation MAY BE REQUESTED at the discretion of the COR.

The Contractor must use the IPP website to register, access and use IPP for submitting requests for payment. The Contractor Government Business Point of Contact (as listed in SAM) will receive enrollment instructions via email from the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis (FRBSTL) within 3 – 5 business days of the contract award date. Contractor assistance with enrollment can be obtained by contacting the IPP Production Helpdesk via email IPPCustomerSupport@fiscal.treasury.gov or phone (866) 973-3131.

If the Contractor is unable to comply with the requirement to use IPP for submitting invoices for payment, the Contractor must submit a waiver request in writing to the Contracting Officer with its proposal or quotation.

Department of the Interior Acquisition Regulation (DIAR) 1452.201-70 Authorities and delegations. Authorities and Delegations (SEP 2011)

As prescribed in section 1401.670-1, insert the following clause:

- (a) The Contracting Officer is the only individual authorized to enter into or terminate this contract, modify any term or condition of this contract, waive any requirement of this contract, or accept nonconforming work.
- (b) The Contracting Officer will designate a Contracting Officer's Representative (COR) at time of award. The COR will be responsible for technical monitoring of the contractor's performance and deliveries. The COR will be appointed in writing, and a copy of the appointment will be furnished to the Contractor. Changes to this delegation will be made by written changes to the existing appointment or by issuance of a new appointment.
- (c) The COR is not authorized to perform, formally or informally, any of the following actions:
- (1) Promise, award, agree to award, or execute any contract, contract modification, or notice of intent that changes or may change this contract;
 - (2) Waive or agree to modification of the delivery schedule;
 - (3) Make any final decision on any contract matter subject to the Disputes Clause;
 - (4) Terminate, for any reason, the Contractor's right to proceed;
 - (5) Obligate in any way, the payment of money by the Government.
- (d) The Contractor shall comply with the written or oral direction of the Contracting Officer or authorized representative(s) acting within the scope and authority of the appointment memorandum. The Contractor need not proceed with direction that it considers to have been issued without proper authority. The Contractor shall notify the Contracting Officer in writing, with as much detail as possible, when the COR has taken an action or has issued direction (written or oral) that the Contractor considers to exceed the COR's appointment, within 3 days of the occurrence. Unless otherwise provided in this contract, the Contractor assumes all costs, risks, liabilities, and consequences of performing any work it is directed to perform that falls

within any of the categories defined in paragraph (c) prior to receipt of the Contracting Officer's response issued under paragraph (e) of this clause.

(e) The Contracting Officer shall respond in writing within 30 days to any notice made under paragraph (d) of this clause. A failure of the parties to agree upon the nature of a direction, or upon the contract action to be taken with respect thereto, shall be subject to the provisions of the Disputes clause of this contract.

(f) The Contractor shall provide copies of all correspondence to the Contracting Officer and the COR.

(g) Any action(s) taken by the Contractor, in response to any direction given by any person acting on behalf of the Government or any Government official other than the Contracting Officer or the COR acting within his or her appointment, shall be at the Contractor's risk.

(End of clause)

DOI AAAP-0050_V3 Notice to Contractors--Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (December 2015)

- 1) [FAR 42.1502](#) directs all Federal agencies to collect past performance information on contracts. The Department of the Interior (DOI) has implemented the Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) to comply with this regulation. One or more past performance evaluations will be conducted in order to record your contract performance as required by [FAR 42.15](#).
- 2) The past performance evaluation process is a totally paperless process using CPARS. CPARS is a web-based system that allows for electronic processing of the performance evaluation report. Once the report is processed, it is available in CPARS for Government use in evaluating past performance as part of a source selection action.
- 3) We request that you furnish the Contracting Officer (CO) with the name, position title, phone number, and email address for each person designated to have access to your firm's past performance evaluation(s) for the contract no later than **30 days after award**. Each person granted access will have the ability to provide comments in the Contractor portion of the report and state whether or not the Contractor agrees with the evaluation, before returning the report to the Assessing Official (AO). Information in the report must be protected as source selection sensitive information not releasable to the public.
- 4) When your Contractor Representative(s) are registered in CPARS, they will receive an automatically generated email with detailed login instructions. Further details, systems requirements, and training information for CPARS is available at <https://www.cpars.gov/>.
- 5) Within 60 days after the end of a performance period, the AO will complete an interim or final past performance evaluation, and the report will be accessible at <https://www.cpars.gov/>.
 - a) Contractor Representatives may then provide comments in response to the evaluation, or return the evaluation without comment.
 - b) Your comments should focus on objective facts in the AO's narrative and should provide your views on the causes and ramifications of the assessed performance.
 - c) All information provided should be reviewed for accuracy prior to submission.
 - d) If you elect not to provide comments, please acknowledge receipt of the evaluation by indicating "No comment" in the space provided, and then selecting "Accept the Ratings and Close the Evaluation".

- e) Your response is due within 60 calendar days after receipt of the CPAR. On day 15, the evaluation will become available in CPARS marked as “Pending” with or without comments and whether or not it has been closed.
- f) If you do not sign and submit the CPAR within 60 days, it will automatically be returned to the Government and will be annotated: "The report was delivered/received by the contractor on (date). The contractor neither signed nor offered comment in response to this assessment."
- 6) The following guidelines apply concerning your use of the past performance evaluation:
 - a) Protect the evaluation as source selection information. After review, transmit the evaluation by completing and submitting the form through CPARS. If for some reason you are unable to view and/or submit the form through CPARS, contact the CO for instructions.
 - b) Strictly control access to the evaluation within your organization. Ensure the evaluation is never released to persons or entities outside of your control.
 - c) Prohibit the use of or reference to evaluation data for advertising, promotional material, pre-award surveys, responsibility determinations, production readiness reviews, or other similar purposes.
- 7) If you wish to discuss a past performance evaluation, you should request a meeting in writing to the CO no later than seven days following your receipt of the evaluation. The meeting will be held in person or via telephone or other means during your 60-day review period.
- 8) A copy of the completed past performance evaluation will be available in CPARS for your viewing and for Government use supporting source selection actions after it has been finalized.

3.2 PROVISIONS

FAR 52.252-1 Solicitation Provisions Incorporated by Reference. (Feb 1998)

This solicitation incorporates one or more solicitation provisions by reference, with the same force and effect as if they were given in full text. Upon request, the Contracting Officer will make their full text available. The offeror is cautioned that the listed provisions may include blocks that must be completed by the offeror and submitted with its quotation or offer. In lieu of submitting the full text of those provisions, the offeror may identify the provision by paragraph identifier and provide the appropriate information with its quotation or offer. Also, the full text of a solicitation provision may be accessed electronically at this/these address(es):

<https://www.acquisition.gov>

The following Provisions are hereby incorporated by reference:

Provision	Title	Date
52.203-11	Certification and Disclosure Regarding Payments to Influence Certain Federal Transactions	Sep 2024
52.203-18	Prohibition on Contracting with Entities that Require Certain Internal Confidentiality Agreements or Statements-Representation	Jan 2017
52.204-7	System for Award Management—Registration	Nov 2024

52.209-2	Prohibition on Contracting with Inverted Domestic Corporations—Representation	Nov 2015
52.209-5	Certification Regarding Responsibility Matters	Aug 2020
52.209-7	Information Regarding Responsibility Matters	Oct 2018
52.209-11	Representation by Corporations Regarding Delinquent Tax Liability or a Felony Conviction under any Federal Law	Feb 2016
52.212-1	Instructions to Offerors—Commercial Products and Commercial Services	Sep 2023
52.217-5	Evaluations of Options	July 1990
52.229-11	Tax on Certain Foreign Procurements—Notice and Representation	Jun 2020
52.204-92	Security Requirements	Dec 2025
52.240-93	Basic Safeguarding of Covered Contractor Information Systems	Dec 2025

(End of provision)

FAR 52.252-5 Authorized Deviations in Provisions (Nov 2020)

(a) The use in this solicitation of any Federal Acquisition Regulation (48 CFR Chapter 1) provision with an authorized deviation is indicated by the addition of "(DEVIATION)" after the date of the provision.

(b) The use in this solicitation of any Department of the Interior Acquisition Regulation (48 CFR Chapter 14) provision with an authorized deviation is indicated by the addition of "(DEVIATION)" after the name of the regulation.

(End of provision)

DIAR 1452.215-71 Use and Disclosure of Proposal Information—Department of the Interior (APR 1984)

(a) Definitions. For the purposes of this provision and the Freedom of Information Act (5 U.S.C. 552), the following terms shall have the meaning set forth below:

(1) “Trade Secret” means an unpatented, secret, commercially valuable plan, appliance, formula, or process, which is used for making, preparing, compounding, treating or processing articles or materials which are trade commodities.

(2) “Confidential commercial or financial information” means any business information (other than trade secrets) which is exempt from the mandatory disclosure requirement of the Freedom of Information Act, 5 U.S.C. 552. Exemptions from mandatory disclosure which may be applicable to business information contained in proposals include exemption (4), which covers “commercial and financial information obtained from a person and privileged or confidential,” and exemption (9), which covers “geological and geophysical information, including maps, concerning wells.”

(b) If the offeror, or its subcontractor(s), believes that the proposal contains trade secrets or confidential commercial or financial information exempt from disclosure under the Freedom of Information Act, (5 U.S.C. 552), the cover page of each copy of the proposal shall be marked with the following legend:

“The information specifically identified on pages _____ of this proposal constitutes trade secrets or confidential commercial and financial information which the offeror believes to be exempt from disclosure under the Freedom of Information Act. The offeror requests that this

information not be disclosed to the public, except as may be required by law. The offeror also requests that this information not be used in whole or part by the government for any purpose other than to evaluate the proposal, except that if a contract is awarded to the offeror as a result of or in connection with the submission of the proposal, the Government shall have the right to use the information to the extent provided in the contract.”

(c) The offeror shall also specifically identify trade secret information and confidential commercial and financial information on the pages of the proposal on which it appears and shall mark each such page with the following legend:

“This page contains trade secrets or confidential commercial and financial information which the offeror believes to be exempt from disclosure under the Freedom of Information Act and which is subject to the legend contained on the cover page of this proposal.”

(d) Information in a proposal identified by an offeror as trade secret information or confidential commercial and financial information shall be used by the Government only for the purpose of evaluating the proposal, except that (i) if a contract is awarded to the offeror as a result of or in connection with submission of the proposal, the Government shall have the right to use the information as provided in the contract, and (ii) if the same information is obtained from another source without restriction it may be used without restriction.

(e) If a request under the Freedom of Information Act seeks access to information in a proposal identified as trade secret information or confidential commercial and financial information, full consideration will be given to the offeror's view that the information constitutes trade secrets or confidential commercial or financial information. The offeror will also be promptly notified of the request and given an opportunity to provide additional evidence and argument in support of its position, unless administratively unfeasible to do so. If it is determined that information claimed by the offeror to be trade secret information or confidential commercial or financial information is not exempt from disclosure under the Freedom of Information Act, the offeror will be notified of this determination prior to disclosure of the information.

(f) The Government assumes no liability for the disclosure or use of information contained in a proposal if not marked in accordance with paragraphs (b) and (c) of this provision. If a request under the Freedom of Information Act is made for information in a proposal not marked in accordance with paragraphs (b) and (c) of this provision, the offeror concerned shall be promptly notified of the request and given an opportunity to provide its position to the Government. However, failure of an offeror to mark information contained in a proposal as trade secret information or confidential commercial or financial information will be treated by the Government as evidence that the information is not exempt from disclosure under the Freedom of Information Act, absent a showing that the failure to mark was due to unusual or extenuating circumstances, such as a showing that the offeror had intended to mark, but that markings were omitted from the offeror's proposal due to clerical error.

(End of provision)

FAR 52.233-2 Service of Protest Department of the Interior (JUL 1996) (Deviation)

(a) Protests, as defined in section 33.101 of the Federal Acquisition Regulation, that are filed directly with an agency, and copies of any protests that are filed with the Government Accountability Office (GAO), shall be served on the Contracting Officer (Michael McGuire, 381 Elden Street, Suite 2000A, Herndon, VA 20170; mike_mcguire@ibc.doi.gov) by obtaining written and dated acknowledgment of receipt from the Contracting Officer.

- (b) The copy of any protest shall be received in the office designated above within one day of filing a protest with the GAO.
- (c) A copy of the protest served on the Contracting Officer shall be simultaneously furnished by the protester to the Department of the Interior Assistant Solicitor for Procurement and Patents, 1849 C Street, NW, Room 6511, Washington, D.C. 20240."

(End of Provision)

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SECTION 4 – QUOTATION PREPARATION & SUBMISSION INSTRUCTIONS

4.1 General Instructions

The following instructions are included in addition to FAR provision 52.212-1. This acquisition will be conducted in accordance with FAR Part 12 for the purpose of entering into a Purchase Order.

Quoters shall submit a Technical and Price quote. Each must be submitted as a separate volume. Quoters shall not include pricing information in their Technical Volume.

4.2 Submission Requirements

Contractors are required to submit the following documents: a written Technical quote, Past Performance, Assumptions, Conditions, or Exceptions, draft Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan and a Price quote to Government officials for the purposes of assuring that the prospective contractor is fully cognizant of the scope of this purchase order and has the capability to complete all requirements of the Performance of Work Statement.

4.2.1 **FORMAT FOR QUOTES**

The contractor shall submit an electronic copy of their quote containing the following:

- Volume I –Technical (20-page limit)
- Volume II – Past Performance (no page limit)
- Volume III – Assumptions, Conditions or Exceptions (no page limit)
- Volume IV – Draft Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (no page limit)
- Volume V – Price (no page limit)

The cover page must cite the following:

- Company Name
- Mailing Address
- System for Award Management (SAM) Unique Entity Identifier (UEI)
- Complete business mailing address as it appears in SAM
- Contact name, phone number, and e-mail address
- RFQ Number
- Date submitted and Quote Expiration Date

Quoters are required to be registered in SAM at www.sam.gov as of the date the quotation is submitted. The quoter's SAM registration shall be in "active" status.

Quotations that do not meet all the requirements specified in this RFQ may not be considered.

4.3 Volume I – Technical Submission

Page Limit: Limited to twenty (20) pages, cover letter, and table of contents. Pages in excess of 20 will not be evaluated.

Format: 12-point font, single-spaced, 8.5x11 paper. Graphics/tables may use 8-point font.

Technical: The technical quote should define in detail the contractor's technical approach to meeting the requirements defined in the Performance Work Statement. The narrative with the contractor's quote must be written in a clear, concise fashion describing precisely what the contractor proposes to do to meet those requirements. The technical quote should include, but is not limited to the following information:

1. General technical approach to meeting the requirements of the Performance Work Statement including potential problems and proposed solutions.

In addition to the topics specified herein, the technical submission may address any other topics considered to be pertinent to demonstration of the knowledge, competence, and capability to complete the tasks identified in the Performance Work Statement. The quote package should be in the form of a detailed written quote describing how the work will be performed and who will perform the work.

Past Performance: Contractors shall identify three (3) contracts/task orders with the Federal Government and/or commercial customers that demonstrate recent and relevant past performance. Recent is defined as within the last three years. Relevant is defined as work similar in complexity and magnitude of the work described in this Performance Work Statement. Please provide three references of similar efforts performed by your organization for the last three years. Include a description of the project, project title, contract number, contract amount, client identification including agency or company name, contracting and technical reviewing official, address, telephone number, and email address.

The Government shall also consider information obtained through other sources. Past performance information will be utilized to determine the quality of the contractor's past performance as it relates to the probability of success of the required effort.

Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan: The Offeror shall provide a draft QASP that includes requirements that define the work in measurable terms, measure performance standards tied to the requirements, a plan and methodology for measuring performance against standards, and a detailed process used to evaluate contractor performance against standards.

The Offeror shall effectively demonstrate a successful Quality Assurance Plan (QAP) which aligns with the draft Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (QASP), training and orientation program, and effective approach to provide timely and accurate records and reports. A final QAP will be due within 30 days after the Government acceptance of the QASP.

Please see refer to Section 5.0, Performance Requirements Summary of the PWS.

Price Submittal

GENERAL REQUIREMENTS: Your price portion shall be a separate volume from the technical portion.

SPECIFIC REQUIREMENTS: The Contractor shall propose a pricing structure in accordance with their proposed technical solution. Contractors should provide the labor categories and labor hours appropriate for their proposed solution to meet the requirements of this effort, and any other proposed associated costs that the basis for calculating the proposed price of this effort. The price submission must have a total estimate for the entire period of performance.

You are encouraged to discount your offer. If a discount is provided please indicate the non-discounted rates, the proposed percentage of discount and the discounted rate. In the spirit of cost transparency, cost savings to the taxpayer, and to the Federal Government, please consider voluntarily waiving or reducing labor rate escalation within your price submission for this project. Also, please summarize the savings you are providing to the government through this additional discounting effort.

Assumptions, Conditions, OR Exceptions: The contractor must submit, under separate cover, all (if any) assumptions, conditions, or exceptions with any of the contractual, technical, and/or cost/price terms and conditions of this RFQ. These assumption, conditions or exceptions do not count toward the page limit of the technical proposal. If not noted in this volume of your quote, it will be assumed that the contractor proposes no assumptions for award and agrees to comply with all of the terms and conditions as set forth herein. It is not the responsibility of the Government to seek out and identify assumptions, conditions, or exceptions buried within the contractor's submission.

Assumptions, conditions or exceptions which an offeror sets forth may affect the acceptability of its quote.

4.4 Due Date and Time

Quotes must be received via email to Michael McGuire (mike_mcguire@ibc.doi.gov) and Jacqueline Hernandez (jacqueline_hernandez@ibc.doi.gov) no later than **10:00 A.M. ET, May 04, 2026**. Reference **"Quote – 140D0426Q0324"** in the subject line.

The Government reserves the right to contact a Quoter regarding their quote including to request additional discounts.

Late submissions may not be considered for evaluation at the discretion of the Contracting Officer. No faxed or hard copy quotes will be accepted.

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[END OF SECTION 4]

SECTION 5 - EVALUATION OF QUOTATIONS

5.1 Basis for Award

The first two technical factors, Technical Approach, Solution, Capabilities and Understanding and Past Performance, are of equal importance and when combined are more important than Price. Price is the least important factor.

Quotes will be reviewed and evaluated in accordance with the evaluation criteria identified below:

Technical Approach, Solution, Capabilities and Understanding

- Past Performance
- Price

Evaluation of Non-Price Factor A and B

VOLUME I: TECHNICAL SUBMISSION

Factor A: Technical Approach, Solution, Capabilities and Understanding

The Government will evaluate the following items:

- **Understanding of the Requirement:**
 - Outline the use rate of the AI Chatbot solution, based on historic traffic patterns for peacecorps.gov.
 - The responder shall describe their methodology for optimizing the solution's efficiency, balancing response quality with computational cost
 - Clarity and thoroughness in demonstrating understanding of the objectives of the PWS and specific tasks, including integration with the Peace Corps website, RAG dataset implementation, multilingual functionality, and NLP capabilities.
 - Creativity and feasibility of proposed solutions to meet operational goals, including lead generation, applicant conversion, and reduced staff workload.
 - Ability to address potential anticipated problem areas and future needs, and feasibility of solutions to evolve and work with new processes and technology enhancements (e.g., advanced AI features, enhanced user experience, or streamlined administrative workflows).
- **System Architecture and Technical Implementation:**
 - Quality of the proposed solution's technical design, including FedRAMP High authorization, uptime and SLA adherence, scalability, and optimization strategies.
 - Ability to integrate with Peace Corps workflows, content management systems, and live agent escalation.
- **Security, Privacy, and Compliance:**

- Demonstrated ability to meet FedRAMP High standards, CUI and PII protection, HIPAA handling, and adherence to federal AI, privacy, and accessibility standards.
- Proposed methods for risk management, emergency response, and human oversight of AI operations.

VOLUME II: PAST PERFORMANCE

The Government will evaluate the following items:

Factor B: Past Performance

- The organization's history of successful completion of projects; history of producing high-quality reports and other deliverables; history of staying on schedule and within budget within the past 3 years will be accepted.
- The organization's specific past performance on prior similar efforts specified within the PWS.

VOLUME V: PRICE

Factor C: Price

The Contractor is expected to quote a reasonable price. An evaluation of each Contractor's price quote will be made to determine if it is reasonable for the work to be performed, reflects a clear understanding of the requirements, and is consistent with the proposed technical solution.

Each price quote will be assessed to identify potential risk. Price risk refers to any aspect of a Contractor's quote which could have significant negative price consequences for the Government. Where risk is assessed it may be described in qualitative terms or used as a best-value discriminator.

BASIS FOR AWARD:

The Government will place an order using the procedures in FAR Part 12. Award will be made to the responsible vendor whose quotation, conforming to this solicitation, is judged to provide the "Best Value" to the Government, all factors considered. Technical Approach, Solution, Capabilities and Understanding and Past Performance, are of equal importance and when combined are more important than Price. Price is the least important factor. As submissions become technically equal in quality, price will become a major consideration in selecting the successful contractor.

The Government may reject any quote that is evaluated to be significantly non-compliant with the solicitation requirements or reflects a failure to comprehend the complexity and risks of the work to be performed.

Trade Offs:

The Government reserves the right to make an award to other than the low priced Contractor if the superior technical submission, or the submission indicating a reduced performance risk,

warrants paying a premium. The Government's objective is to obtain the highest technical quality considered necessary to achieve the project objectives, with a reasonable price.

Submission of a quote implies the Quoter agrees to the terms and conditions in this document. The Government reserves the right to not issue an award from this RFQ. This is an RFQ only and in no way obligates the Government to award a Purchase Order or to reimburse the Quoter for any costs incurred in preparing the response to this RFQ.

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[END OF SECTION 5]

SECTION 6 – SOLICITATION DOCUMENTS, EXHIBITS, AND ATTACHMENTS

Attachment 1	PWS
Attachment 2	Limitations on Subcontracting Report

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[END OF SECTION 6]



PERFORMANCE WORK STATEMENT (PWS)

PEACE CORPS

The Office of Volunteer Recruitment and Service (VRS)

VRS AI Chatbot Solution to Enhance Agency Recruitment Efforts

Date: March 16, 2026

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2.0 GENERAL

2.1 BACKGROUND

On March 1, 1961, President John F. Kennedy established the United States Peace Corps to promote world peace and friendship. The Peace Corps' mission has three simple goals:

- Helping people of interested countries in meeting their needs for trained men and women.
- Helping promote a better understanding of Americans on the part of the people served.
- Helping promote a better understanding of other peoples on the part of Americans.

Since its founding, the Peace Corps has served in 140 developing countries, and more than 240,000 American citizens have served as Peace Corps Volunteers (PCVs).

Currently, the Peace Corps (the Agency) has over 3,200 Volunteers working with local communities in 56 host countries (Posts) in six sectors: agriculture, community economic development, education, environment, health and youth in development. Most Volunteers serve for a term of 2 years (today, this is called the PCV program). A smaller number of Volunteers serve for shorter 3 – 12-month renewable assignments and have more advanced skills (these are the Peace Corps Response (PCR) and Global Health Services Partnership (GHSP) programs). In addition, Peace Corps now offers remote volunteering opportunities through the Virtual Service Pilot (VSP) program.

The Peace Corps has approximately 2,500 employees: around 350 work in the United States, and more than 2,200 work overseas at Posts throughout the world. The Office of Volunteer Recruitment and Service (VRS) is newly responsible, after consolidations, for recruiting candidates for all four programs: PCV, PCR, GHSP and VSP.

In the past decade, especially with the acceleration prompted by the COVID pandemic, Peace Corps has embraced a more virtual and mobile work environment. This shift necessitates advanced, accessible recruitment strategies to meet the evolving expectations of both staff and potential volunteers. In addition, the U.S. Office of Personnel Management (OPM) is encouraging Federal agencies to implement and incorporate leading-edge, proactive strategies and technologies.

Peace Corps has already successfully implemented an automated marketing system that lives natively in the Agency's Customer Relationship Management (CRM) system, where all current lead interactions are initiated and recorded. This system facilitates outreach through email, events, video conferences, web forms and, to a limited extent, text. Peace Corps is aiming to increase interactions with leads, and the general public,

through more channels, specifically conversational artificial intelligence (AI), meeting the next generation of Volunteers and anyone connected to the Peace Corps, wherever they prefer, in a consistent voice and manner, regardless of the form of outreach. This includes, but is not limited to, highlighting opportunities to segmented audiences, reminding people of upcoming deadlines, answering commonly asked questions of all kinds, appropriately directing people to the right resource or staff, and assisting potential and current applicants in a variety of other ways.

2.2 SCOPE

With this desire for increased outreach and flexibility, the Peace Corps is committed to improving customer service for potential applicants and all stakeholders by implementing a public-facing, web-based, conversational AI agent into its existing recruitment efforts and outreach systems. This solicitation is for the acquisition of licenses and services to implement and integrate a conversational AI Chatbot solution into the peacecorps.gov website. Training of the Peace Corps staff in the new system and solutions for its continual upkeep and improvement shall also be required.

2.2.1 Current Web Traffic and Projected Use

Respondents to this solicitation will need to formulate expected use rate of the AI Chatbot solution, based on historic traffic patterns for peacecorps.gov.

The Peace Corps website experienced the following traffic in CY2025:

- Views: 14,347,579
- Active users: 3,974,235
- Active users/day: 10,888 (Note, this is not uniform. Traffic often peaks on Mondays at around 50K and then declines steadily over the course of the week.)
- Page views/user: 3.61

In addition, traffic for the Peace Corps website is projected to increase by 12 to 14% in CY2026.

Peacecorps.gov also contains a “Connect With a Recruiter” request form for people actively seeking assistance: <https://www.peacecorps.gov/connect/recruiter/>.

Although this request form is directed at leads and potential applicants, and that compromises most submissions, people use it for a wide variety of inquiries.

The number of people who interacted with the “Connect With a Recruiter” form in CY2025:

- Views: 190, 418
- Users: 82,804

- Submissions: 49,772

Through the above form and various other means of entering Peace Corps' recruitment and marketing CRM, Peace Corps recruitment staff currently engage in approximately 5000 website generated conversations a month with members of the public. These conversations may consist of as little as one exchange and as many as 20 exchanges, however, recruitment staff estimate total exchanges at approximately 20,000 a month through these website generated interactions.

The numbers above offer a baseline for projection, but Peace Corps assumes engagement from the public will dramatically increase with the implementation of a conversational AI agent. All respondents should take this into consideration.

2.3 OBJECTIVE

Through the implementation of a conversational AI Chatbot solution, the Peace Corps expects to:

- Facilitate more effective and efficient interactions between potential applicants with recruiters and the marketing team.
- Generate new leads through an additional marketing channel.
- Increase the number of leads converted into applicants through better just-in-time communications.
- Decrease the time and effort Peace Corps staff spend responding to commonly asked questions and requests for guidance from the public that can be answered through thoughtfully constructed technology.
- Provide smoother and more seamless interactions between the public and Peace Corps through escalation of AI generated conversations, when required, to the relevant Peace Corps staff.

3.0 REQUIREMENTS/TASKS

3.1 AI COMMUNICATION SERVICE SOLUTION REQUIREMENTS

3.1.1 FedRAMP High Authorization

The Contractor shall provide a FedRAMP High Authorization approved, commercially available SaaS, conversational AI solution to enable two-way communication between the Peace Corps and the public. This service solution shall be referred to as the "Chatbot" throughout the remainder of this performance work statement.

3.1.2 Service Level Agreements (SLAs)

The Chatbot shall adhere to SLAs for system uptime, incident response time, and issue resolution. As a minimum, the solution shall maintain a 99.9% uptime during business hours.

3.1.3 Integration with the Peace Corps Website

The Chatbot shall be mobile optimized with a responsive interface that seamlessly integrates with the Peace Corps website, www.peacecorps.gov. Although the Peace Corps website is currently built on the Django 5/Wagtail 8 Content Management Systems (CMS), the Chatbot shall be solution agnostic and work with current and future peacecorps.gov architecture.

3.1.4 Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)

To prevent hallucinations, misguidance and incorrect answers, the AI shall rely solely on a RAG and all source material shall be limited to Peace Corps' curated dataset. This dataset shall consist of selected sections of the Peace Corps website (peacecorps.gov), publicly facing documents, internal documents, customized workflows created for the Chatbot, and other forms of information gathering custom designed for the RAG. The RAG shall contain a means for hierarchical ranking of data, so that the Chatbot can distinguish between more and less important information. Peace Corps estimates the RAG shall be between 1,000 and 10,000 pages upon initial deployment.

3.1.5 Continuous Learning

The Chatbot shall include continuous learning mechanisms to improve responses over time, such as real-time capture of user interactions for later analysis and human-in-the-loop model updates, feedback loops for content updates, and regular optimization of the Chatbot's knowledge base and interaction flows to align with evolving organizational needs and priorities. The learning model should be flexible, allowing for updates based on policy changes, new user data, removal of datasets and advancements in AI technology. Peace Corps staff shall be trained to oversee and run this process without dependence upon the contractor or provider.

3.1.6 Optimization

The responder shall describe their methodology for optimizing the solution's efficiency, balancing response quality with computational cost. This may include features such as model selection options or query optimization techniques. The Chatbot interface shall load on the website parallel to page on which it resides. The average response time for user queries shall be commensurate with currently established industry standards/expectations.

3.1.7 Modifying and Retrieving Knowledge Dataset

The solution shall allow the Peace Corps to continuously add, modify or edit the propriety dataset that the Chatbot uses for its RAG knowledge base, improving and curating the language model, without disruptions to the service.

3.1.8 User Experience

The Chatbot shall identify itself as a bot to Users but interact and provide guidance in a voice and manner consistent with Peace Corps' values and ethos. The Chatbot shall support interaction with a wide and highly segmented audience, appropriately crafting responses specific to the conversation and needs at hand. Users shall feel a sense of continuity and personalization whether they are interacting with the Peace Corps via chatbot, the website, email, or a person.

3.1.9 Multilingual Functionality with an English Dataset

The Chatbot shall support interaction in multiple languages, while using a single source RAG populated entirely with an English dataset. The Chatbot shall be able to seamlessly translate between supported languages, and understand, use and define common Peace Corps' acronyms.

3.1.10 Natural Language Processing (NLP)

The Chatbot shall have advanced NLP capabilities to accurately understand, interpret, and respond to user inquiries in natural language. The solution shall handle a wide range of topics relevant to the agency's mission and user needs, ensuring efficient, engaging, and contextually appropriate user experience.

3.1.11 Live Agent or Customer Service Transfer

The Chatbot shall ensure seamless integration for transferring users to staff or customer service representatives when needed. This feature shall be easily accessible to users and operate without significant delays, ensuring a smooth transition from automated to human support. In addition, Peace Corps staff shall be able to take over live conversations from the Chatbot as necessary. The Chatbot shall contain robust queue management protocols, including real-time tracking of user positions in the queue, estimated wait times, and notifications if delays occur, and, when live support is not available, call back capabilities for the next business day. End users shall have the option to request a callback or remain in the queue. Queue management shall also include mechanisms for load balancing among available agents to optimize response times and ensure efficient distribution of inquiries across the customer service team.

3.1.12 Innovation and Scalability

The Chatbot shall ensure that the communications service is scalable to accommodate for future features and capabilities. The Chatbot shall support an increasing number of users and a higher volume of interactions over time.

3.1.13 Compliance with Legal and Ethical Standards

The Chatbot shall comply with all relevant legal and ethical standards, including but not limited to the [AI in Government Act](#), the [Federal Data Strategy](#), and applicable privacy laws such as the [California Consumer Privacy Act \(CCPA\)](#). The Chatbot shall also adhere to the agency's AI governance framework, ensuring ethical use, fairness, and non-discrimination in all interactions.

3.1.14 Fair and Non-Discriminatory Operation

The Chatbot shall operate in a fair and non-discriminatory manner, and shall abide by the requirements of all applicable federal statutes, regulations and government-wide policies, such as but not limited to [Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964](#) and [Obligations of Contractors and Subcontractors](#). The communication solution must be designed to treat all users equally, without bias or discrimination based on race, gender, age, religion, disability, sexual orientation, or any other protected characteristic. Regular audits and testing must be conducted to identify and mitigate any potential biases in the system's responses or interactions.

3.1.15 Emergency Response and User Safety

The Chatbot shall implement safety protocols to detect and respond to emergencies, such as language or behavior indicating a user is in immediate danger (e.g., self-harm). The communication solution shall be capable of guiding users to appropriate resources, such as emergency services or hotlines, and shall ensure that such interactions are handled with utmost sensitivity and care.

3.1.16 Human Oversight

The Chatbot shall ensure that the solution operates under appropriate human oversight, particularly in scenarios where AI responses may affect user rights or safety. The solution shall incorporate checkpoints where human intervention is required, especially in situations that could have significant implications for users. All actions or responses generated by the Chatbot that impact users shall be documented and reviewed by authorized personnel to ensure adherence to agency policies and regulations.

3.1.17 Analytics and Reporting

The Chatbot shall include comprehensive analytics and reporting capabilities to track user engagement across all channels. This shall include areas such as user satisfaction, response accuracy, adoption rates, containment rate (percentage of queries resolved without human escalation), escalation rate and most frequent user intents/topics, to offer insights into user behavior and interaction patterns, enabling data-driven decisions to enhance communication strategies and messaging usage.

3.1.18 Key Performance Indicators (KPI) Dashboard

The Chatbot shall contain a live dashboard or regular reports that monitor the KPIs, including user satisfaction, response accuracy, and adoption rates.

3.1.19 Usage Report

The Chatbot shall contain a live dashboard or regular reports that monitor usage. If necessary, the Chatbot shall have the capability to notify designated Peace Corps staff when messaging usage has reached a certain threshold.

3.1.20 AI Risk Management

The Chatbot shall ensure effective management of risks associated with the use of AI technologies. This includes identifying, evaluating, and mitigating potential risks,

such as unintended consequences, algorithmic biases, and ensuring compliance with federal and agency-specific AI guidelines.

3.1.21 Transparency and Accountability

The Chatbot shall include documentation of decision-making processes and maintain transparency in all AI operations, clearly informing users when they are interacting with an AI system. The Chatbot shall ensure that all AI-driven decisions and suggestions are explainable, providing users and agency personnel with understandable rationales for the outputs, and citing source materials when and where appropriate and possible.

3.1.22 Data Collection, Retention, and Usage

The Chatbot shall ensure that all data collected is handled in accordance with the agency's [data governance policies](#). Data must be stored and segmented securely, with clear protocols for temporary and long-term storage and have protections in place such as Separate Data Streams, Private Chat Windows, Data Masking Mechanisms and Redaction Tools. The Chatbot shall adhere to Peace Corps data retention policies that dictate how long data is stored, with options for secure deletion or anonymization at the end of the retention period. User consent must be obtained for data collection by the Chatbot, and users should be informed by the Chatbot about the type of data being collected and its intended use.

3.1.23 Protected Communications Compliance

The Chatbot shall adhere to the highest standards of security and privacy, ensuring that all user communications are protected. The service shall comply with relevant federal regulations and data protection laws, safeguarding user information and maintaining the integrity of communications. The Chatbot shall understand and comply with HIPAA requirements, redirecting audience members with HIPAA protected questions to qualified Peace Corps staff.

3.2 POST- AWARD KICKOFF MEETING

Within 10 business days of the start of performance, the Contractor will conduct a virtual post-award kickoff meeting. Specific date and time to be mutually agreed upon.

3.2.1 Quality Assurance Control Plan

The Contractor shall create a Quality Assurance Control Plan (QASP) covering all task areas and deliverables in accordance with the Performance Work Statement within 15 days after the start of performance and the final QASP for acceptance within 30 days after the start of performance to the Contracting Officers Representative (COR) and the Contracting Officer. The plan shall demonstrate how the Contractor shall ensure quality performance and satisfy the requirements of the PWS.

3.2.2 Project Plan

The Contractor shall develop an initial Project Plan within 15 days after the start of performance for the implementation and operation of the proposed products, including timelines, resource requirements utilization and milestone dates. The project plan shall also allow for the Agency's change management and security review processes.

The Contractor shall maintain and update the project plan to reflect the status of the contract activities and projected milestone completion dates. Changes to the project plan shall be noted in the Status report deliverable.

3.2.3 Requirements Specification Document

The Contractor shall develop a detailed Requirements Specification Document that captures all functional and non-functional requirements for the communication services. This document must be reviewed and approved by the agency before the design phase begins. Delivery is expected within 30 days after the kickoff meeting.

3.2.4 Design and Architecture Documentation

The Contractor shall provide a Design and Architecture Document that details the technical design, system architecture, integration points, and data flows for the Chatbot. This document must be delivered within 45 days following the approval of the Requirements Specification Document. The design documentation shall describe how the solution will be implemented, this shall include the following information:

- How the solution is hosted.
- How the solution integrates and shares information with Peace Corps.
- What accounts and permissions are needed for the operations of the solution.
- How automated chatbot interactions function.
- What maintenance and licensing are needed to maintain the operation of the solution.

The design documentation will be used in the Peace Corps change management process to obtain approval for implementation.

3.2.5 Transparency and Accountability

The Contractor shall develop and maintain documentation of decision-making which shall be accessible to authorized personnel to support transparency and accountability.

3.2.6 Meetings

For all meetings, the Contractor shall be responsible for providing meeting materials and administrative and facilitation support. Meetings will be conducted virtually or through an alternative method of communication (such as teleconferencing), as approved by the Contracting Officer.

3.2.6.1 *Intermittent Project Status Reviews*

At the sole discretion of the Government, intermittent project status reviews may be conducted on an informal basis (by telephone, teleconference, or virtually) upon 3 business days advance notice as approved by the Contracting Officer or other authorized official as COR.

3.2.6.2 *Monthly Project Status Reviews*

Monthly status meetings to be conducted by the 10th of each month. The Contractor is responsible for reporting the previous month's activities (including any risks, issues, or concerns, and actual or recommended actions for their mitigation), and projected activities for the following month.

3.2.6.3 *Program Management Review*

The Government will conduct monthly, quarterly, etc., program management virtual reviews to review the progress of the program, identify any risks, issues, or concerns, and provide feedback on the Contractor's progress and performance. The Contractor shall provide written data and verbal presentations as to the overall status of the VRS Communications Service services, any identified any risks, issues, or concerns (and the mitigation or its plans for the mitigation.)

3.3 SECURITY AND DATA PROTECTION TASKS

3.3.1 Data Privacy and Security

The Chatbot shall include FIPS 140-2 compliant encryption of sensitive information both in transit and at rest, secure session management, and compliance with federal and agency-specific data protection regulations. The Chatbot shall adhere to data minimization principles, retaining only the necessary data to fulfill its operational purpose, and securely deleting or anonymizing data according to retention policies.

3.3.2 Data Protection Plan

The Contractor shall provide a comprehensive Data Protection Plan that outlines how data will be protected throughout its lifecycle. This plan should include details on data encryption (in transit and at rest), access controls, data retention and deletion policies, incident response procedures, compliance with relevant data protection regulations, and data backup and recovery strategies. The Data Protection Plan must be submitted within 15 days of the start of the period of performance and updated as necessary throughout the contract period.

3.3.3 Security Assessment Support

The Contractor shall provide necessary support for government-conducted security assessments. This includes providing required documentation and being available as needed to answer security-controlled questions during Peace Corps security assessments. This limited support is required as requested throughout the contract period.

3.3.4 User Safety Rights

The Contractor shall provide technical information pertaining to the Chatbot for any waiver requests related to safety-impacting or rights-impacting AI tools. The technical information is to be received within 15 calendar days of the request.

3.3.5 Exit Strategy and Data Portability

Upon contract termination, the Contractor shall provide a complete, machine-readable export of all Government-owned data. This includes, but is not limited to, the curated RAG dataset, customized workflows, conversation logs, and user feedback. The format for this data export shall be a non-proprietary, industry-standard format (e.g., JSON, CSV).

3.4 DEPLOYMENT TASKS

3.4.1 Final Communication Services Solution

The Contractor shall deploy the final, fully functional chatbot, integrated and tested, across all intended platforms. This final solution must be delivered within 60 days of the successful completion of the final document documentation, testing and cybersecurity risk management and assessment phases.

3.4.2 Training Materials and Knowledge Transfer

The Contractor shall provide comprehensive training materials, including user manuals, training guides, and video tutorials. A training session must be conducted for agency staff, and all materials must be delivered within 10 days before the Chatbot goes live.

4.0 DELIVERABLES

4.1 PRIME DELIVERABLES

The Contractor shall deliver the following functionality to satisfy the objective of this PWS.

4.1.1 Chatbot

The Contractor shall provide an AI chatbot that meets the performance requirements described in the [AI Communication Service Solution Requirements](#) and the [Chatbot Solution Requirements](#) sections of this PWS.

4.2 GENERAL MANAGEMENT

The Contractor shall provide the following deliverables for all activities to show the status of contract activities and to manage the delivery of the prime deliverables.

4.2.1 Status Report

The Contractor shall provide a status update for all activities under this contract in monthly reports on the 10th of the month with invoice, excluding weekends and holidays, up until release into production/go live. This shall include progress made in the previous month, activities planned for the upcoming month and risks to the project plan and continuing operations.

4.2.2 Contract Reports

The Contractor shall provide:

- Meeting Minutes 5 business days after the conclusion of meetings.

4.2.3 Final Report

The Contractor shall provide:

- Final status report within 30 calendar days from the release into production/go live.

4.2.4 Project Plan

The Contractor shall provide an initial Project Plan within 15 days after the start of performance for the implementation and operation of the proposed products, including timelines, resource requirements utilization and milestone dates. The project plan shall also allow for the Agency's change management and security review processes.

The Contractor shall maintain and update the project plan to reflect the current status of the contract activities and projected milestone completion dates. Changes to the project plan shall be noted in the Status report deliverable.

4.2.5 Data Protection Plan

The Contractor shall provide a comprehensive Data Protection Plan that outlines how data will be protected throughout its lifecycle. This plan should include details on data encryption (in transit and at rest), access controls, data retention and deletion policies, incident response procedures, compliance with relevant data protection regulations, and data backup and recovery strategies. The Data Protection Plan must be submitted within 15 days of the start of the period of performance and updated as necessary throughout the contract period.

4.2.6 Requirements Specification Document

The Contractor shall deliver a detailed Requirements Specification Document that captures all functional and non-functional requirements for Chatbot services. This document must be reviewed and approved by the agency before the design phase begins. Delivery is expected within 30 days after the kickoff meeting.

4.2.7 Design and Architecture Documentation

The Contractor shall provide a Design and Architecture Document that details the technical design, system architecture, integration points, and data flows for the Chatbot. This document must be delivered within 45 days following the approval of the Requirements Specification Document. The design documentation shall describe how the solution will be implemented, this shall include the following information:

- How the solution is hosted.
- How the solution integrates and shares information with other Peace Corps systems.
- What accounts and permissions are needed for the operations of the solution.

- How automated chatbot interactions function.
- What maintenance and licensing are needed to maintain the operation of the solution.

The design documentation will be used in the Peace Corps change management process to obtain approval for implementation.

4.2.8 Integration Plan and Report

The Contractor shall deliver an Integration Plan detailing how the Chatbot will be integrated with the agency's website. Following the successful integration, a report documenting the process, challenges, and outcomes must be delivered within 15 days of the integration.

4.2.9 Implementation Plan

The Contractor shall document how the proposed solution will be implemented for review and acceptance, including timelines, affected Peace Corps systems, resource requirements, and backout plans. This plan must be submitted 45 days before the scheduled implementation date and will be used in the Peace Corps change management process to obtain approval for implementation.

The implementation plan will be used in the Peace Corps change management process to obtain approval for implementation.

The implementation plan can be incremental to implement functionality progressively.

4.2.10 Test Plan & Results

The Contractor shall provide a testing plan that documents how the proposed solution will be tested for review and acceptance prior to testing. This plan must be submitted 30 days prior to the scheduled start of testing. The Contractor shall also provide the final successful results of UAT testing within 10 days after the completion of UAT testing prior to implementation.

4.2.11 Usability Testing Report

The Contractor shall conduct usability testing with representative user groups and deliver a comprehensive Usability Testing Report. This report should include feedback analysis, compliance with accessibility standards, and recommendations for improvements. The report is due within 15 days after the final prototype is delivered.

4.2.12 User Acceptance Testing

The Contractor shall conduct UAT with Peace Corps staff to ensure that the Chatbot meets all functional and non-functional requirements as specified. The UAT must be completed within 30 days following the delivery of the final design document. The results of UAT must be documented and delivered in a Test Results report within 10 days after the completion of UAT.

4.2.13 Training Materials and Knowledge Transfer

The Contractor shall provide comprehensive training materials, including user manuals, training guides, and video tutorials. A training session must be conducted for agency staff, and all materials must be delivered within 10 days before the Chatbot goes live.

4.2.14 Final Chatbot Solution

The Contractor shall deliver the final, fully functional chatbot, integrated, tested, and ready for deployment on the Peace Corps' website. This final solution must be delivered within 60 days of the successful completion of the final design document, testing and cybersecurity risk management and assessment phases.

4.2.15 Key Performance Indicators Dashboard

The Contractor shall deliver a live dashboard or regular reports that monitor the Chatbot's KPIs, including user satisfaction, response accuracy, and adoption rates. The first dashboard/report must be delivered within 15 days of the Chatbot going live, with regular updates as specified by the agency.

5.0 PERFORMANCE REQUIREMENTS SUMMARY

The Contractor service requirements are summarized into performance objectives that relate directly to mission essential items. The performance threshold briefly describes the minimum acceptable levels of service required for each requirement. These thresholds are critical to mission success.

<i>Performance Objective</i>	<i>Performance Standard</i>	<i>Performance Threshold</i>	<i>Method of Surveillance</i>
The Contractor shall provide all required products and services within the specified time requirements	The Contractor provided Hardware and Software Configuration	Contractor meets the specified time requirement 95% of the time	Periodic surveillance by the COR or Government designee

6.0 ADDITIONAL CONTRACTOR REQUIREMENTS:

6.1 CLOUD INFORMATION SYSTEMS – IT SECURITY AND PRIVACY REQUIREMENTS

The Contractor shall implement the controls contained within the FedRAMP Cloud Computing Security Requirements Baseline and FedRAMP Continuous Monitoring Requirements for Moderate impact systems (as defined in [FIPS PUB 199](#)). These documents define requirements for compliance to meet minimum Federal information security and privacy requirements for **Moderate** impact systems. The FedRAMP baseline controls are based on NIST (National Institute for Standards and Technology)

[Special Publication 800-53, Revision 5](#), “*Security and Privacy Controls for Federal Information Systems and Organizations*,” and also include a set of additional controls for use within systems providing cloud services to the Federal Government.

Peace Corps may choose to terminate the contract if the Contractor has its FedRAMP authorization (Joint Authorization Board [JAB] Provisional or Agency) revoked, and the deficiencies are greater than agency risk tolerance thresholds.

6.1.1 Assessment of the System

The Contractor shall comply with FedRAMP requirements as mandated by Federal laws and policies, including making available any documentation, physical access, and logical access needed to support this requirement throughout the life of the contract. The Level of Effort for the Assessment and Authorization (A&A) is based on the System’s FIPS PUB 199 categorization. The Contractor shall create, maintain and update the following documentation in accordance with the Initial Authorization Package Checklist using FedRAMP requirements and templates, which are available at [FedRAMP.gov](#). (See [Appendix B for FedRAMP Initial Authorization Checklist](#).) Information systems must be assessed by an accredited FedRAMP Third Party Assessment Organization (3PAO) initially and whenever there is a significant change to the system’s security posture in accordance with the FedRAMP Continuous Monitoring Plan.

The Government reserves the right to perform Security Assessment and Penetration Testing (of its instance). If the Government exercises this right, the Contractor shall allow Government employees (or designated third parties) to conduct Security Assessment and Penetration Testing activities to include control reviews in accordance with FedRAMP requirements. Penetration Testing shall be supported by mutually agreed-upon Rules of Engagement (RoE). Review activities include but are not limited to manual penetration testing; automated scanning of operating systems web applications; wireless scanning; network device scanning to include routers, switches, firewalls, and IDS/IPS; databases and other applicable systems, including general support structure, that support the processing, transportation, storage, or security of Government information for vulnerabilities.

The Contractor shall provide access to the Federal Government or their designee acting as their agent when requested in order to verify compliance with the requirements for an Information Technology security program. The Contractor shall make appropriate personnel available for interviews and provide all necessary documentation during this review.

Physical Access Considerations – If the Cloud Service Provider (CSP) is operated within an Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS) that is FedRAMP authorized (e.g., AWS), physical access to the physical data center environment will be governed by the terms of access allowed by the underlying infrastructure provider as defined in the FedRAMP A&A authorization package.

Identified gaps between required FedRAMP Security Control Baselines and Continuous Monitoring controls and the Contractor's implementation as documented in the Security Assessment Report shall be tracked by the Contractor for mitigation in a Plan of Action and Milestones (POA&M) document. Depending on the severity of the gaps, the Government may require them to be remediated before a Peace Corps authorization is issued.

The Contractor shall be responsible for mitigating all security risks found during A&A and continuous monitoring activities. All critical vulnerabilities must be remediated within seven days, high-risk vulnerabilities must be mitigated within 14 days, and all moderate-risk vulnerabilities must be mitigated within 45 days from the date vulnerabilities are formally identified in accordance with Peace Corps policy. The Government will determine the risk rating of vulnerabilities.

6.1.2 Authorization of the System

Peace Corps will leverage the CSP's (contractor) FedRAMP Assessment and Authorization package to document and assess the customer controls for which Peace Corps has responsibility and issue a Peace Corps ATO for the agency's instance of the CSP's Software as a service (SaaS) or Service as a Service (PaaS) offering. The CSP shall work with the Peace Corps to facilitate documentation and assessment of required customer controls, as necessary. The product shall be designated FedRAMP authorized.

Note: CSPs must comply with all FedRAMP Baseline Controls. Additionally, the CSP shall implement Peace Corps provided specific parameter settings as set forth in the Peace Corps Control Tailoring Workbook- Government Furnished Material (GFM) to be provided at the kickoff meeting.

The CSP shall ensure these essential security controls are implemented and operate as intended.

Further, the CSP shall make the proposed system and security architecture of the information system available to the Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO) security team of assigned Information Security Officers (ISSOs) and Subject Matter Experts (SME) for review and approval before the commencement of system build (architecture, infrastructure, and code (as applicable)) and/or the start of A&A in support of the Initial Authorization Package and Continuous Monitoring activities.

6.1.3 Reporting and Continuous Monitoring

Maintenance of the FedRAMP Authorization will be through continuous monitoring and periodic audit of the operational controls within the Contractor's system, environment, and processes to determine if the security controls in the information system continue to be effective over time in light of changes that occur in the system and environment. Through continuous monitoring, security controls and supporting deliverables must be updated in agreement with FedRAMP guidelines and submitted to the repository designated by the FedRAMP program.

The submitted deliverables provide a current understanding of the security state and risk posture of the information systems. The deliverables will allow the Peace Corps to leverage the service providers' cloud offering to make credible risk-based decisions regarding the continued operations of the information systems and initiate appropriate responses as needed when changes occur. Contractors shall be required to provide updated deliverables and automated data feeds as defined in the FedRAMP Continuous Monitoring Plan.

In compliance with the Peace Corps agency-specific authorization, the Contractors shall, on a monthly basis (when), collaborate with the ISSO team to provide access to the required deliverables to ensure the CSP maintains an appropriate risk posture. The Contractor shall furnish access to the following deliverables:

- Monthly OS, database, and web application vulnerability scans as specified in the NIST SP 800-53 Control RA-5 parameter in Peace Corps' Control Tailoring Workbook (deliverable shall include raw results and findings shall be included in the POA&M document);
- Monthly Plan of Action and Milestones (POA&M);
- Change requests (as they occur); and
- Incidents (as they occur)

Upon achievement of FedRAMP authorization, the Peace Corps will accept the FedRAMP A&A and continuous monitoring documentation made available on the repository designated by the FedRAMP program in agreement with FedRAMP guidelines to satisfy the continuous monitoring requirement.

6.1.4 Personnel Security Requirements

Contractor shall furnish documentation reflecting favorable adjudication of background investigations for all personnel (including Subcontractors) supporting the solution. Peace Corps separates the risk levels for personnel working on Federal computer systems as follows:

- Before accessing the Peace Corps network or any Peace Corps IT system, a favorable initial fitness/suitability determination must be granted, and a Tier 1 or higher background investigation must be initiated. There shall be no waivers to this requirement for Peace Corps network and IT system access for Peace Corps employees or Contractors.
- A favorable initial fitness/suitability determination must be granted, and a Tier 2 or higher background investigation must be initiated before access to Personally Identifiable Information (PII)/ Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) is granted. The authority and access shall be determined by the

appropriate Peace Corps Supervisor (for Peace Corps employees) or CO (for contract personnel), the Data Owner, and the System's AO. Each System's AO, with the request of the Peace Corps Supervisor, Data Owner or CO, shall evaluate the risks associated with each such request.

- A favorable suitability determination must be completed at a Tier 2 or higher background investigation before privileged access to the Peace Corps network or IT systems is granted. A waiver may be requested in order to maintain Peace Corps business operations; however, such requests should be used judiciously and not incur unnecessary risks to Peace Corps.

If final adjudication of a background investigation is unfavorable, Peace Corps network and IT system access must be revoked, and any GFE, including the Peace Corps PIV card, must be retrieved and returned to OS&S.

Peace Corps shall sponsor the investigation when deemed necessary. No access shall be given to Government computer information systems and Government sensitive information without a background investigation being verified or in process. If the results of the background investigation are not acceptable, then access shall be terminated.

The Contractor shall provide a monthly report on separated staff beginning 60 days after the execution of the option period.

6.1.5 Sensitive Information Storage

Controlled Unclassified Information, data, and/or equipment will only be disclosed to authorized personnel on a need-to-know basis. The Contractor shall ensure that appropriate administrative, technical, and physical safeguards are established to ensure the security and confidentiality of this information, data, and/or equipment is properly protected. When no longer required, this information, data, and/or equipment will be returned to Government control, destroyed, or held until otherwise directed. Destruction of items shall be accomplished by [following NIST Special Publication 800-88](#), *“Guidelines for Media Sanitization.”* The destruction, purging or clearing of media specific to the CSP will be recorded and supplied upon request of the Government.

6.1.6 Protection of Information

The Contractor shall be responsible for properly protecting all information used, gathered, or developed as a result of work under this contract. The Contractor shall also protect all Government data, equipment, etc., by treating the information in accordance with its Federal Information Security Modernization Act (FISMA) system categorization.

All information about the systems gathered or created under this contract should be considered CUI information. If Contractor personnel must remove any information from the primary work area that is included in the ATO boundary, they should

protect it to the same FedRAMP requirements. The use of any information that is subject to the Privacy Act will be utilized in full accordance with all rules of conduct as applicable to Privacy Act Information.

6.1.7 *Unrestricted Rights to Data*

The Government will retain unrestricted rights to Government data. The Government retains ownership of any user-created/loaded data and applications hosted on the contractor's infrastructure and maintains the right to request full copies of these at any time.

6.1.8 *Personally Identifiable Information*

The contractor shall assist in preparing a Privacy Threshold Assessment (PTA) to either document that PII storage is not in scope or determine which categories of information will be stored, processed, or transmitted by the system. The use of any information that is subject to the Privacy Act will be utilized in full accordance with all rules of conduct as applicable to Privacy Act Information.

PII will require the following guidelines to be adhered to.

- The vendor's information system must be authorized at least at the FIPS PUB 199 Moderate level.
- For any system that collects, maintains or disseminates PII, the Contractor must complete a PIA and provide it to the Peace Corps Privacy Office for review along with the other authorization to operate (ATO) documents.
- If the system retrieves information using PII, the Privacy Act applies, and a system of records notice (SORN) must be published in the Federal Register.
- If PII is collected from individuals by the system, a Privacy Act Statement (i.e., Privacy Notice) must be provided to users prior to their use of the application on what data is being collected and why, as well as the authority for the collection and the impact of not providing some or all of it. The Privacy Act Statement must be available to the individual directly on the form used to collect the information. Providing a link back to the Statement from the form is acceptable.

6.1.9 *Data Availability*

The data must be available to the Government upon request within one business day or within the timeframe negotiated with the Contractor and shall not be used for any other purpose other than that specified herein. The Contractor shall provide requested data at no additional cost to the Government.

6.1.10 *Data Release*

Any information made available to the Contractor by the Government shall be used only for the purpose of carrying out the provisions of this contract and shall not be

divulged or made known in any manner to any persons except as may be necessary in the performance of the contract. In the performance of this contract, the Contractor assumes responsibility for the protection of the confidentiality of Government records and shall ensure that all work performed by its SubContractors shall be under the supervision of the Contractor or the Contractor's responsible employees. Each officer or employee of the Contractor or any of its SubContractors to whom any Government record may be made available or disclosed shall be notified in writing by the Contractor that information disclosed to such officer, or employee can be used only for that purpose and to the extent authorized herein. Further disclosure of any such information, by any means, for a purpose or to an extent unauthorized herein, may subject the offender to criminal sanctions imposed by 18 U.S.C. §§ 1030.

The Contractor shall not disclose Customer Data to any Government or third party or access or use Customer Data, except in each case as necessary to maintain the Cloud Services or to provide the Cloud Services to Customer in accordance with this contract, or as necessary to comply with the law or a valid and binding order of a governmental or regulatory body (such as a subpoena or court order). Unless it would violate a court order or other legal requirement, the Contractor will give the Government reasonable notice of any such legal requirement or order to allow the Government to seek a protective order or other appropriate remedy.

6.1.11 Data Ownership

All Government data collected in the system is the property of the Federal Government. The Contractor (system provider) shall provide all data collected by the system as requested during the contract period and at the completion of the contract period.

6.1.12 Confidentiality and Nondisclosure

Personnel working on any of the described tasks may, at the Government's request, be required to sign formal non-disclosure and/or conflict of interest agreements to guarantee the protection and integrity of Government information and documents. Additionally, any information made available to the Contractor by the Government shall be used only for the purpose of carrying out the provisions of this contract and shall not be divulged or made known in any manner to any persons except as may be necessary for the performance of the contract. In the performance of this contract, the Contractor assumes responsibility for the protection of the confidentiality of Government records and shall ensure that all work performed by its Subcontractors shall be under the supervision of the Contractor or the Contractor's responsible employees. Each officer or employee of the Contractor or any of its Subcontractors to whom any Government record may be made available or disclosed shall be notified in writing by the Contractor that information disclosed to such officer, or employee can be used only for that purpose and to the extent authorized herein. Further disclosure of any such information, by any means, for a purpose or to an extent unauthorized herein, may subject the offender to criminal sanctions imposed by 18 U.S.C. §§ 1030.

6.1.13 Peace Corps Non-Disclosure Agreement

Each individual Contractor/Subcontractor employee who performs work on this contract is required to sign an Employee Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA). The Contractor shall submit to the COR a completed confidentiality and NDA for each individual Contractor/Subcontractor.

The Contractor and all Contractor/Subcontractor employees may have access to sensitive data, proprietary, or confidential business information of other companies or the Government in the course of performing official duties on this contract. The term “proprietary information” means any information considered so valuable by its owners that it is held in secret by them and their licensees and is not available to the public.

All information that is (1) obtained related to or derived from this contract and (2) results from or derived from any actual tasks assigned to Contractor employees while participating in this contract is considered proprietary.

The Contractor and all Contractor/Subcontractor employees shall not use vendor proprietary information except as necessary to perform this contract and shall agree not to disclose such information to third parties, including any employee of the Contractor/Subcontractor who has not executed this NDA or use such information in any manner inconsistent with the purpose for which it was obtained. Anyone failing to comply with the agreement may be subject to disciplinary action or termination of employment by the Contractor/Subcontractor and possible administrative, civil, or criminal penalties.

Note: Peace Corps’s Office of the General Counsel (OGC) is available to coordinate on defining NDA requirements AOR. Upon request, Peace Corps OGC can advise on NDA development.

6.1.14 Additional Stipulations

Deliverables shall be labeled CUI or Contractor-selected designation per document sensitivity. External transmission/dissemination of CUI to or from a Government computer must be encrypted. Certified encryption modules must be used in accordance with [FIPS PUB 140-2](#), “*Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules*. ”

The Contractor shall certify applications are fully functional and operate correctly as intended on systems using benchmarks from Peace Corps technical guidelines, NIST guidelines, Center for Internet Security guidelines, or industry best practice guidelines, as reviewed and accepted by the Peace Corps AO. The standard installation, operation, maintenance, update, and/or patching of software shall not alter the configuration settings from the approved benchmark configuration.

Information technology for Windows systems should use the Windows Installer Service for installation to the default “program files” directory and should be able to

install and uninstall silently. Applications designed for normal end users shall run in the standard user context without elevated system administration privileges. The Contractor shall use tools to verify their products operate correctly with the approved benchmark configurations and not alter the benchmark settings.

The Contractor shall cooperate in good faith in defining the NDA that other third parties must sign when acting as the Federal government's agent.

Note: Peace Corps' OGC is available to coordinate on defining NDA requirements AOR. Upon request, Peace Corps OGC can advise on NDA development.

The Contractor shall comply with any additional FedRAMP privacy requirements. The Government has the right to perform manual or automated audits, scans, reviews, or other inspections of the vendor's IT environment being used to provide or facilitate services for the Government. The Contractor shall be responsible for the following privacy and security safeguards:

- a. The Contractor shall not publish or disclose in any manner, without the Contracting Officer's written consent, the details of any safeguards either designed or developed by the Contractor under this contract or otherwise provided by the Government. Exception - Disclosure to a Consumer Agency for purposes of A&A verification or to the designated FedRAMP portal. To the extent required to carry out a program of inspection to safeguard against threats and hazards to the security, integrity, and confidentiality of Government data, the Contractor shall afford the Government access to the Contractor's facilities, installations, technical capabilities, operations, documentation, records, and databases within 72 hours of the request. The Contractor shall provide logical access to support incident investigations in accordance with defined FedRAMP Incident Response procedures and/or Peace Corps Incident Response services, which shall be provided as soon as possible but not longer than 72 hours after request.
- b. Physical Access Considerations—If the SaaS provider operates within an IaaS that is FedRAMP authorized (e.g., AWS), physical access to the physical data center environment will be governed by the terms of access allowed by the underlying infrastructure provider as defined in the FedRAMP A&A authorization package.
- c. The program of inspection shall include, but is not limited to:
 - Authenticated and unauthenticated operating system/network vulnerability scans
 - Authenticated and unauthenticated web application vulnerability scans

- Automated scans can be performed by Government personnel or agents acting on behalf of the Government, using Government-operated equipment and Government-specified tools. If the vendor chooses to run its own automated scans or audits, results from these scans may, at the Government's discretion, be accepted in lieu of Government performed vulnerability scans. In these cases, scanning tools and their configuration shall be approved by the Government. In addition, the results of vendor-conducted scans shall be provided in full to the Government.
- d. If new or unanticipated threats or hazards are discovered by either the Government or the Contractor, or if existing safeguards have ceased to function, the discoverer shall immediately bring the situation to the attention of the other party.

The Contractor shall comply with Section 1634 of [Public Law 115-91](#) that prohibits the use of any hardware, software, or services developed or provided, in whole or in part, by— (1) Kaspersky Lab (or any successor entity); (2) any entity that controls, is controlled by or is under common control with Kaspersky Lab; or (3) any entity of which Kaspersky Lab has majority ownership.

The Contractor shall comply with 52.204-25 of the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR). It prohibits, under Section 889(a)(1)(A) of the John S. McCain National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 2019 (Pub. L. 115-232), Contractors from providing to the Government any equipment, system, or service that uses telecommunications equipment or video surveillance services from certain named companies as a substantial or essential component of any system, or as critical technology as part of any system, unless an exception or waiver is granted per the FAR. It also prohibits, under Section 889(a)(1)(B), Contractors from using any equipment, system, or service that uses telecommunications or video surveillance equipment or services from certain named companies as a substantial or essential component of any system or as critical technology as part of any system, unless an exception or waiver is granted per the FAR. The proscribed companies are Huawei Technologies Company, ZTE Corporation, Hytera Communications Corporation, Hangzhou Hikvision Digital Technology Company, and Dahua Technology Company and their subsidiaries and affiliates.

6.2 SYSTEM ACCESSIBILITY AND EASE OF USE

Pursuant to Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 (29 U.S.C. 794d) as amended by P.L. 105-220 under Title IV (Rehabilitation Act Amendments of 1998) all Electronic and Information Technology (EIT) developed, procured, maintained and/or used under this contract shall comply with the "Electronic and Information Technology Accessibility Standards" set forth by the Architectural and Transportation Barriers Compliance Board (also referred to as the "Access Board") in 36 CFR Part 1194. The complete text of Section 508 Standards can be accessed at <http://www.access-board.gov/> or at <http://www.section508.gov>.

The Contractor shall comply with the following technical standards as applicable:

- 1194.21 Software applications and operating systems
- 1194.22 Web-based intranet and internet information and applications
- 1194.23 Telecommunications products
- 1194.24 Video and multimedia products
- 1194.25 Self-contained, closed products
- 1194.26 Desktop and portable computers
- 1194.31 Functional Performance Criteria
- 1194.41 Information, Documentation, and Support

The competitor's response must indicate where full details of compliance can be found (e.g., vendor's website or other exact location).